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TEACHING HISTORY THROUGH FICTION:

THE LAST OF THE MOHICANS AS A CLASSROOM RESOURCE

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Teachers rely on film often. Russell reports that in a study of social studies teachers, every one said they used film at least once a month, and he argues that movies arouse emotion, which helps students remember events, and that they help build historical thinking skills and a general understanding of the past.[1] One film that often appears in lessons on the French and Indian War is Michael Mann's 1992 The Last of the Mohicans, an adaptation of James Fenimore Cooper's 1826 novel, which the archaeologist David Starbuck calls highly fictionalized.[2] Joyce Appleby, a UCLA historian of early America, recommended the film to her own students.[3] Even so, a film that students remember is not necessarily one they can rely on. The Last of the Mohicans gets the look, sound, and setting of the 1757 campaign largely right, but it compresses the timeline, simplifies the violence at Fort William Henry, and gives eighteenth-century characters modern ideas about government, class, and Native peoples. This essay argues that the film is useful in a classroom as a starting point for questions about the war and unreliable as a record of what happened.

The film's strengths lie in its material detail and its military setting. Appleby admired Mann's attention to costumes and sets and his use of French and Native languages, and the studio's production notes list advisers ranging from an eighteenth-century frontier expert to Delaware language instructors. She also thought the forests on screen conveyed how untracked the frontier was, and she agreed with Cooper's point, which the film shows well, that the English and French first had to find each other before they could fight.[4] The basic events are real, too. The American Battlefield Trust dates the siege of Fort William Henry to August 3 through 9, 1757, and names the French general Montcalm as its commander.[5] The British had built the fort in 1755, after the Battle of Lake George, on land the French also claimed, and in 1757 a garrison of about 2,300 men faced a French and Native force several times its size.[6] General Webb, fearing for the defense of Albany, refused to send more troops, and Montcalm showed Monro a captured letter in which Webb suggested he surrender. After several days of bombardment Monro

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[1] William Benedict Russell III, "The Reel History of the World: Teaching World History with Major Motion Pictures," Social Education 76, no. 1 (2012): 22.
[2] The Last of the Mohicans, directed by Michael Mann (1992; Los Angeles: Twentieth Century Fox), 112 min., streamed on Amazon Prime Video (opening credits); David R. Starbuck, "The 'Massacre' at Fort William Henry," Expedition Magazine 50, no. 1 (March 2008), accessed October 1, 2026, https://www.penn.museum/sites/expedition/the-massacre-at-fort-william-henry/.
[3] Jane Galbraith, "Facts of the 'Mohicans': A Historian Is Impressed by the Details in the Movie but Sees Inaccuracies in the Depiction of Frontier Life," Los Angeles Times, October 10, 1992, https://www.latimes.com/archives/la-xpm-1992-10-10-ca-753-story.html.
[4] Galbraith, "Facts of the 'Mohicans.'"
[5] American Battlefield Trust, "Siege of Fort William Henry," accessed October 1, 2026, https://www.battlefields.org/learn/french-indian-war/battles/siege-fort-william-henry.
[6] Starbuck, "'Massacre' at Fort William Henry"; American Battlefield Trust, "Siege of Fort William Henry."

capitulated and received the full honors of war.[7] Mann's film dramatizes the siege, the surrender, and the retreat, including the intercepted dispatch, and its siege scenes are the kind of emotional hook Russell says helps students connect with a historical event and remember it.[8]

Where the film falls short is in its timeline and its handling of the aftermath. The war ran from 1754 to 1763, but the film compresses its romance, rescue, and revenge into the few days around a siege that lasted from August 3 to 9.[9] Viewers never see how slowly the war spread across years and several fronts, or that the fort had stood for two years as an exposed British outpost in the contested country before the French attacked it.[10] The massacre after the surrender is simplified as well. Appleby called the film's version "much less grisly" than what happened in 1757, when Huron warriors, who had allied with the French to trade furs for guns, began taking scalps in the fort's surgery ward and then killed women and children.[11] The record itself is unsettled. Appleby cited an estimated 250 dead in 1992, early chroniclers claimed as many as 1,500, and Starbuck says more recent analysis of period documents puts the number closer to 185.[12] The cause was also more tangled than the film suggests. According to Starbuck, Montcalm's Native allies had been promised scalps and plunder, and the surrender terms effectively denied them both, so the attack on the retreating column was a belated attempt to win trophies and honor.[13] The American Battlefield Trust adds that Montcalm had warned Monro that he might not be able to restrain allies drawn from many different nations, and that the Indians kept about two hundred captives even after Montcalm secured the release of five hundred.[14] The film replaces this mess with Magua, a single vengeful Huron whose quarrel with Colonel Munro is personal, and its massacre sequence centers on his revenge.[15] The title misleads in its own way. The film closes with Chingachgook declaring himself the last of the Mohicans, yet Appleby pointed out in 1992 that Mohican descendants were still alive.[16]

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[7] American Battlefield Trust, "Siege of Fort William Henry."
[8] Mann, Last of the Mohicans, siege, surrender, and retreat sequences; Russell, "Reel History," 22.
[9] American Battlefield Trust, "Siege of Fort William Henry"; Starbuck, "'Massacre' at Fort William Henry"; Mann, Last of the Mohicans, the story's timeline from the party's journey to the retreat.
[10] Starbuck, "'Massacre' at Fort William Henry"; American Battlefield Trust, "Siege of Fort William Henry."
[11] Galbraith, "Facts of the 'Mohicans.'"
[12] Galbraith, "Facts of the 'Mohicans'"; Starbuck, "'Massacre' at Fort William Henry."
[13] Starbuck, "'Massacre' at Fort William Henry."
[14] American Battlefield Trust, "Siege of Fort William Henry."
[15] Mann, Last of the Mohicans, the ambush of the British column after the surrender.
[16] Galbraith, "Facts of the 'Mohicans'"; Mann, Last of the Mohicans, the closing scene.

The film also gives modern values to people of the eighteenth century. Appleby's broadest criticism was that the screenwriters modernized the behavior of the key characters. Colonial militiamen who lecture their British commanders about individual rights, for example, sound as if the independence movement had already begun.[17] Class gets the same treatment. Appleby found it highly improbable that a colonel's daughter like Cora Munro would be drawn to a frontier scout, since people at the time were far more conscious of social rank, and she added that Cora's openness with Hawkeye ignored the formal conventions of the era.[18] That pairing is the film's central romance, and Heyward, the British officer who courts Cora, is the rival who loses.[19] Cooper, Appleby said, was truer to his time. In the novel there is no romance between Hawkeye and Cora, Heyward prefers her younger sister, and it is Magua who loves Cora.[20] Appleby also saw the film's reverent, spiritual portrait of Native Americans as a radical view that shows them living in harmony with nature. That portrait flatters modern sympathies, but it hides the politics of Native nations, such as the Hurons' decision to ally with the French for trade goods.[21] These criticisms point to something useful for teachers. The film reveals more about the values of 1992 than about the beliefs of 1757, so a class can also read it as evidence of how the late twentieth century wanted to imagine the colonial frontier.

A defender of the film could say that it never claimed to be a documentary. That is true, but Russell's own argument shows why it still matters. If movies help students remember events because they stir emotion, then the film's inaccuracies will be remembered along with its accurate details. The American Battlefield Trust makes a related point, noting that film versions of Cooper's story have contained numerous inaccuracies that have shaped later historical interpretations.[22] The film is therefore a good source for the clothing, languages, geography, and military logic of the war, and Appleby judged it closer to colonial history than earlier Hollywood versions.[23] It's a poor record of events, because it blurs the timeline, simplifies the massacre, and gives its characters modern ideas about rights, romance, and Native spirituality. The best way to use it is the way Appleby did. She welcomed students' interest in the film and liked to point out its inaccuracies, because explaining them teaches the history it

[17] Galbraith, "Facts of the 'Mohicans.'"
[18] Galbraith, "Facts of the 'Mohicans.'"
[19] Mann, Last of the Mohicans, the Hawkeye–Cora romance and Heyward's role as rival.
[20] Galbraith, "Facts of the 'Mohicans.'"
[21] Galbraith, "Facts of the 'Mohicans.'"
[22] American Battlefield Trust, "Siege of Fort William Henry."
[23] Galbraith, "Facts of the 'Mohicans.'"

distorts.[24] Russell's four-stage model, which he developed in an article on world history films, has teachers preview the film, stop it at least once to pose questions, and finish by discussing its inaccuracies, a habit of checking drama against evidence.[25] Starbuck writes that after the 1992 release, the owners of the reconstructed fort became eager for new archaeological work, and he excavated there from 1997 to 2000.[26] Used with care, the film does what a good classroom source should do: it raises questions that send students back to the sources.

[24] Galbraith, "Facts of the 'Mohicans.'"
[25] Russell, "Reel History," 22.
[26] Starbuck, "'Massacre' at Fort William Henry."

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